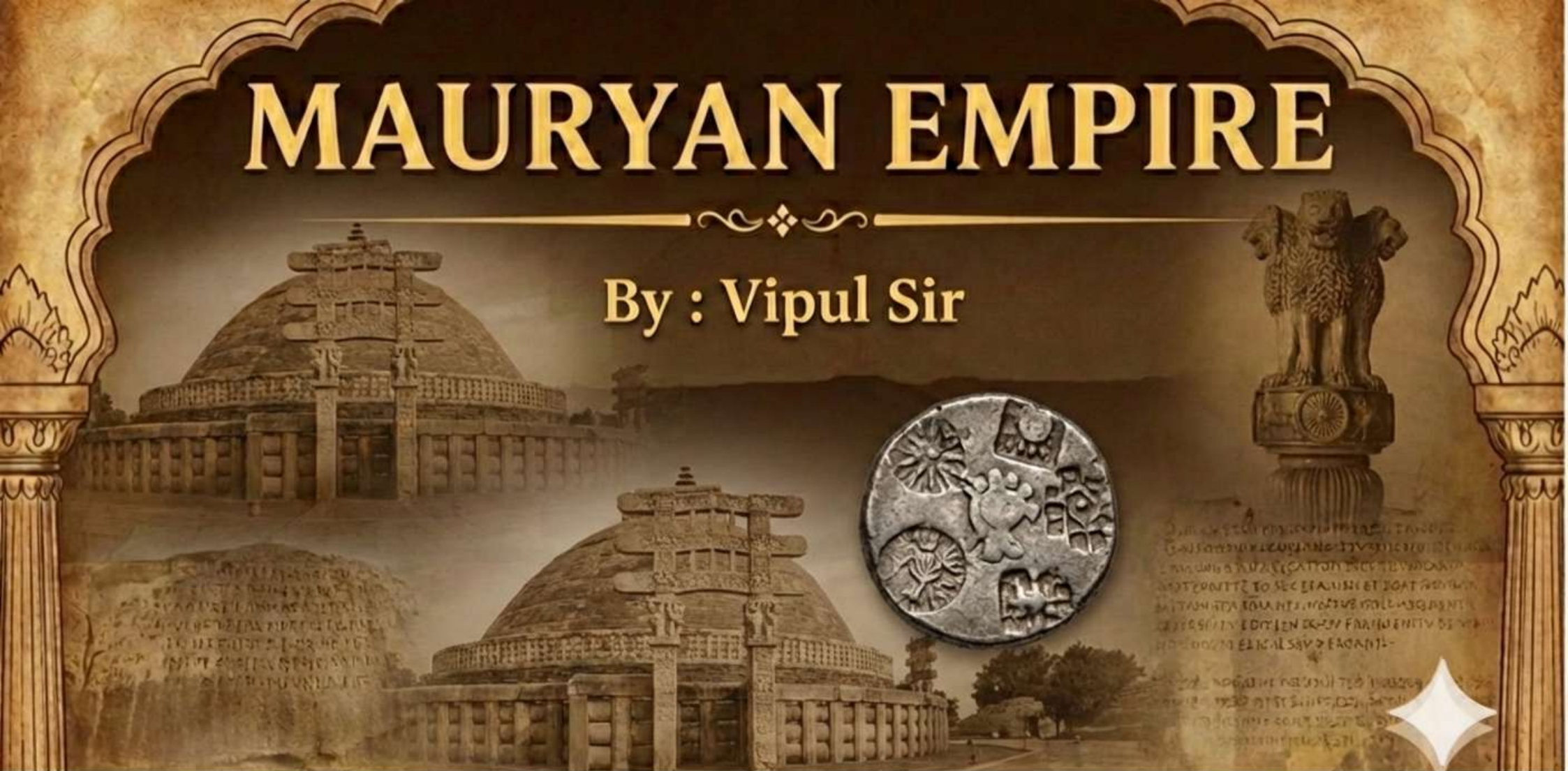


# MAURYAN EMPIRE

By : Vipul Sir



**PARAMOUNT COACHING INSTITUTE DELHI**



# 1. INTRODUCTION & OVERVIEW

| Aspect      | Details                                                                      |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Time Period | 322 BCE - 185 BCE (approximately 137 years)                                  |
| Founder     | Chandragupta Maurya                                                          |
| Capital     | Pataliputra (modern-day Patna, Bihar)                                        |
| Peak Extent | ~5 million km <sup>2</sup> (one of the largest empires of the ancient world) |
| Population  | Estimated 50-60 million people                                               |



## 2. SOURCES OF INFORMATION

### Literary Sources

- **Arthashastra** – Written by Kautilya/Chanakya (treatise on statecraft, economics, military strategy)
- **Indica** – Written by Megasthenes (Greek ambassador to Chandragupta's court)
- **Mudrarakshasa** – Sanskrit play by Vishakhadatta
- **Buddhist texts** – Divyavadana, Mahavamsa, Dipavamsa
- **Jain texts** – Parishishtaparvan by Hemachandra
- **Puranas** – Vishnu Purana, Vayu Purana

### Archaeological Sources

- Ashokan Edicts and Inscriptions
- Coins
- Remains of Pataliputra
- Sanchi Stupa
- Didarganj Yakshi sculpture



# 3. RULERS OF THE MAURYAN EMPIRE

## 3.1 Chandragupta Maurya (322–298 BCE)

| Aspect            | Details                                                                         |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Birth             | c. 340 BCE                                                                      |
| Mentor            | Chanakya (Kautilya/Vishnugupta)                                                 |
| Major Achievement | Overthrew Nanda Dynasty                                                         |
| War               | Defeated Seleucus Nicator (305 BCE)                                             |
| Treaty            | Received regions of Kabul, Kandahar, Herat, Baluchistan                         |
| Marriage Alliance | Married daughter/granddaughter of Seleucus                                      |
| Greek Ambassador  | Megasthenes sent to his court                                                   |
| Death             | Followed Jainism, performed Sallekhana (fasting unto death) at Shravanabelagola |
| Reign Duration    | 24 years                                                                        |

### Key Facts:

- United most of the Indian subcontinent for the first time
- Had a standing army of 600,000 infantry, 30,000 cavalry, 9,000 elephants
- Capital Pataliputra had 64 gates and 570 towers



### 3.2 Bindusara (298–272 BCE)

| Aspect              | Details                                          |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Title               | Amitraghata (Slayer of Enemies)                  |
| Title               | Amitraghata (Slayer of Enemies)                  |
| Greek Name          | Amitrochates                                     |
| Religion            | Followed Ajivika sect                            |
| Greek Ambassador    | Deimachus                                        |
| Achievement         | Extended empire to Deccan                        |
| Areas Not Conquered | Kalinga, Tamil kingdoms, Cheras, Cholas, Pandyas |
| Reign Duration      | 25-28 years                                      |



### 3.3 Ashoka the Great (268-232 BCE)

| Aspect                 | Details                                                       |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Birth Name             | Ashoka Maurya                                                 |
| Titles                 | Devanampiya (Beloved of Gods), Piyadasi (Pleasant to Look At) |
| Accession              | 268 BCE (after a succession war)                              |
| Major Event            | Kalinga War (261 BCE)                                         |
| Kalinga War Casualties | 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported, many more died              |
| Religious Conversion   | Converted to Buddhism after Kalinga War                       |
| Buddhist Teacher       | Upagupta                                                      |
| Reign Duration         | 36-37 years                                                   |
| Death                  | 232 BCE                                                       |



# Ashoka's Dhamma (Policy of Righteousness)

## Core Principles:

- ❁ Tolerance and respect for all religions
- ❁ Non-violence (Ahimsa)
- ❁ Respect for elders, parents, teachers
- ❁ Kindness to servants and slaves
- ❁ Charity and generosity
- ❁ Truth and moral conduct
- ❁ Vegetarianism encouraged

# Ashokan Edicts and Inscriptions

| Type              | Number | Details                                                         |
|-------------------|--------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Major Rock Edicts | 14     | Found in 8 places (Girnar, Kalsi, Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra, etc.) |
| Minor Rock Edicts | 4      | Various locations                                               |
| Pillar Edicts     | 7      | On single stone pillars                                         |
| Cave Inscriptions | 4      | Barabar Caves (for Ajivikas)                                    |



**I PROHIBITION OF ANIMAL SLAUGHTER**  
Bans animal sacrifices and festive gatherings.  
Only two peacocks and one deer killed for royal kitchen, practice to be discontinued.

**II MEDICAL TREATMENT & WELFARE**  
Provides medical care for humans and animals, planting of medicinal herbs, trees, and digging of wells. Mentions South Indian kingdoms.

**III ADMINISTRATIVE & MORAL INSTRUCTIONS**  
Orders officers (Yuktas, Rajukas, Pradesikas) to tour every five years to preach Dhamma, respect parents, and be generous.

**IV DHAMMA-GHOSA OVER BHERI-GHOSA**  
Replaces sound of war drums with sound of Dhamma. Promotes non-violence and moral conduct.

**V APPOINTMENT OF DHAMMA MAHAMATRAS**  
Creation of a new cadre of officers to spread Dhamma, look after welfare of all sects, and prisoners.

**VI KING'S CONCERN FOR PUBLIC WELFARE**  
King is available at all times to attend to public business. Goal is the welfare of all.

**V APPOINTMENT OF DHAMMA MAHAMATRAS**  
Creation of a new cadre of officers to spread Dhamma, look after welfare of all sects, and prisoners.

**VI KING'S CONCERN FOR PUBLIC WELFARE**  
King is available at all times to attend to public business. Goal is the welfare of all.

**VII RELIGIOUS TOLERANCE**  
Flea for tolerance and harmony among all religious sects, all are equal self-centred and pious.

**VIII DHAMMA-YATRAS**  
Ashoka's first pilgrimage to Bodhi Gaya. Replaces royal pleasure tours with Dhamma tours and gifts to Brahmins/Sramanas.

**IX TRUE CEREMONIES**  
Condemns meaningless rituals and ceremonies. Emphasizes ceremonies of Dhamma: courtesy to slaves, reverence to elders.

**X TRUE FAME & GLORY**  
King does not desire fame or glory except for spreading Dhamma and its practice by people.

**XI TRUE FAME & GLORY**  
King does not desire fame or glory except for spreading Dhamma and its practice by people.

**XI GIFT OF DHANNA**  
The best gift is the gift of Dhamma. Includes respect for elders, not killing animals, and kindness.

**XII APPEAL FOR TOLERATION**  
Strong appeal for religious tolerance. Restraint of speech against other sects. Promotion of essence of all religions.

**XIII KALINGA WAR & CONQUEST BY DHAMMA**  
Describes remorse after Kalinga War. Renounces violent conquest for conquest by Dhamma. Renounces the Kalinga War. Mentions Greek kings.

**XIV CONCLUSION**  
Summary of the edicts. Engraved in different places, some abbreviated, some detailed, due to vastness of empire.

EDICT I  
Bans animal sacrifices and festive gatherings. Only two peacocks and one deer killed for royal kitchen, practice to be discontinued.

EDICT II  
Provides medical care for humans and animals, planting of medicinal herbs, trees, and digging of wells. Mentions South Indian kingdoms.

EDICT III  
Orders officers (Yuktas, Rajukas, Pradesikas) to tour every five years to preach Dhamma, respect parents, and be generous.

EDICT IV  
Replaces sound of war drums with sound of Dhamma. Promotes non-violence and moral conduct.

EDICT V  
Creation of a new cadre of officers to spread Dhamma, look after welfare of all sects, and prisoners.

EDICT VI  
King is available at all times to attend to public business. Goal is the welfare of all.

EDICT VII  
Creation of a new cadre of officers to spread Dhamma, look after welfare of all sects, and prisoners.

EDICT VIII  
Ashoka's first pilgrimage to Bodhi Gaya. Replaces royal pleasure tours with Dhamma tours and gifts to Brahmins/Sramanas.

EDICT IX  
Condemns meaningless rituals and ceremonies. Emphasizes ceremonies of Dhamma: courtesy to slaves, reverence to elders.

EDICT X  
King does not desire fame or glory except for spreading Dhamma and its practice by people.

EDICT XI  
The best gift is the gift of Dhamma. Includes respect for elders, not killing animals, and kindness.

EDICT XII  
Strong appeal for religious tolerance. Restraint of speech against other sects. Promotion of essence of all religions.

EDICT XIII  
Describes remorse after Kalinga War. Renounces violent conquest for conquest by Dhamma. Renounces the Kalinga War. Mentions Greek kings.

EDICT XIV  
Summary of the edicts. Engraved in different places, some abbreviated, some detailed, due to vastness of empire.

EDICT XV  
Summary of the edicts. Engraved in different places, some abbreviated, some detailed, due to vastness of empire.



# Important Inscriptions and Missionary Activities of Ashoka

## Important Inscriptions:

- 13th Major Rock Edict – Describes Kalinga War and its horrors
- Bhabru/Bairat Edict – Declares his faith in Buddhism
- Rummindei Pillar – Marks Buddha's birthplace (Lumbini)
- Sarnath Pillar – Lion Capital (now India's national emblem)

## Script Used:

- Brahmi – Most edicts (left to right)
- Kharosthi – Northwest regions (right to left)
- Greek and Aramaic – Afghanistan region

## Ashoka's Missionary Activities

| Region                   | Missionaries                                     |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Kashmir & Gandhara       | Majjhantika                                      |
| Mahishamandala (Mysore)  | Mahadeva                                         |
| Vanavasi                 | Rakkhita                                         |
| Aparantaka (Gujarat)     | Yona Dhammarakkhita                              |
| Maharattha (Maharashtra) | Mahadhammarakkhita                               |
| Ceylon (Sri Lanka)       | Mahendra & Sanghamitra (Ashoka's son & daughter) |
| Suvarnabhumi (Burma)     | Sona & Uttara                                    |
| Central Himalayas        | Majjhima                                         |



## 3.4 LATER MAURVYAN RULERS

| Ruler        | Period      | Notes                                                  |
|--------------|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Kunala       | -           | Son of Ashoka, blinded                                 |
| Dasharatha   | 232–224 BCE | Grandson of Ashoka, gave Barabar caves to Ajivikas     |
| Samprati     | 224–215 BCE | Promoted Jainism                                       |
| Shalishuka   | 215–202 BCE | Weak ruler                                             |
| Devavarman   | 202–195 BCE | -                                                      |
| Shatadhanvan | 195–187 BCE | -                                                      |
| Brihadratha  | 187–185 BCE | Last Mauryan ruler, assassinated by Pushyamitra Shunga |



## 4. ADMINISTRATION

### 4.1 Central Administration

| Official        | Role                             |
|-----------------|----------------------------------|
| King (Rajan)    | Supreme authority, head of state |
| Mantri-Parishad | Council of Ministers             |
| Purohita        | Chief Priest                     |
| Senapati        | Commander-in-Chief               |
| Yuvaraja        | Crown Prince                     |
| Sannidhata      | Treasurer                        |
| Samaharta       | Revenue Collector-General        |
| Prativedaka     | Reporter/Intelligence Officer    |
| Dandapala       | Head of Police                   |

### 4.2 Provincial Administration

| Division                 | Head                      | Modern Equivalent     |
|--------------------------|---------------------------|-----------------------|
| Chakra (Province)        | Kumara/Aryaputra (Prince) | State                 |
| Ahara/Vishaya (District) | Vishayapati               | District              |
| Sthaniya                 | Sthanika                  | Sub-district          |
| Dronmukha                | -                         | Group of 400 villages |
| Kharvatika               | -                         | Group of 200 villages |
| Sangrahana               | -                         | Group of 10 villages  |
| Grama (Village)          | Gramika/Gramani           | Village               |



### 4.3 Four Provincial Capitals

| Province | Capital                        |
|----------|--------------------------------|
| Northern | Taxila                         |
| Western  | Ujjain                         |
| Southern | Suwarnagiri                    |
| Eastern  | Tosali                         |
| Central  | Pataliputra (Imperial Capital) |

### 4.4 City Administration

According to Megasthenes, Pataliputra was governed by a Municipal Committee of 30 members divided into 6 boards of 5 members each:

| Board   | Function                                                     |
|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Board 1 | Industrial arts                                              |
| Board 2 | Foreigners (welfare, accommodation)                          |
| Board 3 | Registration of births and deaths                            |
| Board 4 | Trade and commerce                                           |
| Board 5 | Supervision of manufactured goods                            |
| Board 6 | Collection of sales tax ( $1/10^{\text{th}}$ of sales price) |





#### 4.5 Espionage System

Extensive spy network called Gudhapurushas

Types of spies:

Sanstha - Stationary spies

Sanchari - Wandering spies

Included ascetics, merchants, students, householders

#### 5. JUDICIAL SYSTEM

| Aspect                | Details                                        |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Dharmasthiya Courts   | Civil cases                                    |
| Kantakasodhana Courts | Criminal cases                                 |
| Chief Justice         | Mahamatya                                      |
| Punishments           | Fines, imprisonment, mutilation, death penalty |
| King's Court          | Highest court of appeal                        |



## 6. MILITARY ORGANIZATION

According to Megasthenes

| Branch        | Strength |
|---------------|----------|
| Infantry      | 600,000  |
| Cavalry       | 30,000   |
| War Elephants | 9,000    |
| Chariots      | 8,000    |

Military Board (30 Members in 6 Committees)

| Committee | Function                 |
|-----------|--------------------------|
| 1         | Navy                     |
| 2         | Transport and provisions |
| 3         | Infantry                 |
| 4         | Cavalry                  |
| 5         | Chariots                 |
| 6         | Elephants                |



# 7. ECONOMY

## 7.1 Agriculture

- Land Types: Sita Land – Crown/State land  
Private Land – Owned by individuals
- Irrigation – State provided irrigation facilities
- Chief Agricultural Officer – Sitadhyaksha



## 7.2 Revenue & Taxation

| Tax        | Description                                 |
|------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Bhaga      | King's share (1/6 <sup>th</sup> of produce) |
| Bali       | Religious tribute                           |
| Kara       | Tax on land                                 |
| Shulka     | Customs/toll duty                           |
| Pindakara  | Village tax                                 |
| Hiranya    | Cash payment                                |
| Senabhakta | Army maintenance tax                        |



## 7.3 Trade

- Internal Trade:  
Well-developed roads  
Rajpath – Main highway from Pataliputra to Taxila (precursor to Grand Trunk Road)  
Rest houses along routes
- External Trade: With Greeks, Egyptians  
Exports: Spices, textiles, precious stones, ivory  
Imports: Horses, gold, silver, wine





## 7.4 Important Officials for Economy

| Official       | Role                              |
|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| Sitadhyaksha   | Superintendent of Agriculture     |
| Akaradhyaksha  | Superintendent of Mines           |
| Panyadhyaksha  | Superintendent of Commerce        |
| Sulkadhyaksha  | Superintendent of Customs         |
| Sunadhyaksha   | Superintendent of Slaughter-house |
| Suradhyaksha   | Superintendent of Liquor          |
| Navadhyaksha   | Superintendent of Ships           |
| Mudraadhyaksha | Superintendent of Passports       |

## 7.5 Coinage

Punch-marked silver coins (Karshapana/Pana)

Copper coins (Mashaka)

Weight standard – Based on Raktika (Gunja seed)

1 Pana = 32 Ratti = 57.8 grains of silver





## 8. SOCIETY

### 8.1 Caste System

*According to Megasthenes (7 classes – which was his misinterpretation):  
Philosophers/Brahmins, Farmers, Herdsmen, Artisans, Soldiers, Spies,  
Councilors*

### 8.2 Position of Women

- *Generally respected*
- *Could own property*
- *Remarriage allowed for widows*
- *Women employed as bodyguards, spies*
- *Ganikaadhyaksha – Superintendent of prostitutes*

### 8.3 Slavery

- *Slaves existed but treated relatively well*
- *Megasthenes claimed there were no slaves (incorrect)*
- *Arthashastra mentions different categories of slaves*





## 9. RELIGION

### *Religions During Mauryan Period*

| <i>Religion</i>         | <i>Royal Patronage</i>                     |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <i>Vedic Brahmanism</i> | <i>General population</i>                  |
| <i>Buddhism</i>         | <i>Ashoka</i>                              |
| <i>Jainism</i>          | <i>Chandragupta (later life), Samprati</i> |
| <i>Ajivika</i>          | <i>Bindusara, Dasharatha</i>               |

### *Third Buddhist Council*

- Time: 250 BCE*
- Place: Pataliputra*
- Presided by: Moggaliputta Tissa*
- Patron: Ashoka*
- Outcome: Compilation of Abhidhamma Pitaka*





## 10. ART AND ARCHITECTURE

### 10.1 Pillars

| Pillar             | Location    | Features                                   |
|--------------------|-------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Sarnath Pillar     | Sarnath, UP | Four lions, Lion Capital (National Emblem) |
| Lauriya-Nandangarh | Bihar       | Single lion                                |
| Rampurva           | Bihar       | Bull and Lion capitals                     |
| Sanchi             | Bihar       | Bull and Lion capitals                     |
| Sanchi             | MP          | Four lions                                 |
| Allahabad          | UP          | Later inscriptions added                   |
| Vaishali           | Bihar       | Single lion                                |

#### Characteristics:

- Made of chunar sandstone
- Highly polished (lustrous finish called 'Mauryan Polish')
- Monolithic (single stone)
- Height: 40-50 feet
- Animal capitals (lion, bull, elephant)

### 10.2 Stupas

| Stupa           | Location | Details                           |
|-----------------|----------|-----------------------------------|
| Sanchi Stupa    | MP       | Most famous, gateways added later |
| Bharhut Stupa   | MP       | Elaborate carvings                |
| Amaravati Stupa | AP       | Elaborate medallions              |

Ashoka built 84,000 stupas according to tradition

### 10.3 Cave Architecture

| Cave            | Location | Details                                    |
|-----------------|----------|--------------------------------------------|
| Barabar Caves   | Bihar    | Oldest rock-cut caves, donated to Ajivikas |
| Nagarjuni Caves | Bihar    | Donated by Dasharatha                      |

#### Caves in Barabar Hills:

Lomas Rishi Cave  
Sudama Cave  
Karna Chaupar Cave  
Visva Zopri Cave





#### 10.4 Palace Architecture

*Pataliputra Palace – Inspired by Persian Achaemenid architecture*

*Described by Megasthenes as magnificent*

*Wooden structures, highly decorated*

*Remains found at Kumrahar, Patna*

#### 10.5 Sculptures

*Didarganj Yakshi – Finest example of Mauryan sculpture*

*Highly polished stone sculptures*

*Life-size or larger*

### 11. DECLINE OF THE MAURYAN EMPIRE

#### Causes of Decline

##### Factor

*Weak Later Rulers*

*Division of Empire*

*Financial Crisis*

*Ashoka's Pacifist Policies*

*Brahmanical Reaction*

*Neglect of Northwest*

*Administrative Weaknesses*

*Provincial Rebellions*

##### Explanation

*Successors of Ashoka were incompetent*

*Empire divided after Ashoka's death*

*Huge expenditure on administration, military, Buddhist missions*

*Non-violence weakened military spirit*

*Orthodox Brahmins opposed Ashoka's policies*

*Led to foreign invasions (Greeks, etc.)*

*Over-centralization, vast empire difficult to manage*

*Governors became autonomous*

#### End of the Empire

*Last Ruler: Brihadratha (187-185 BCE)*

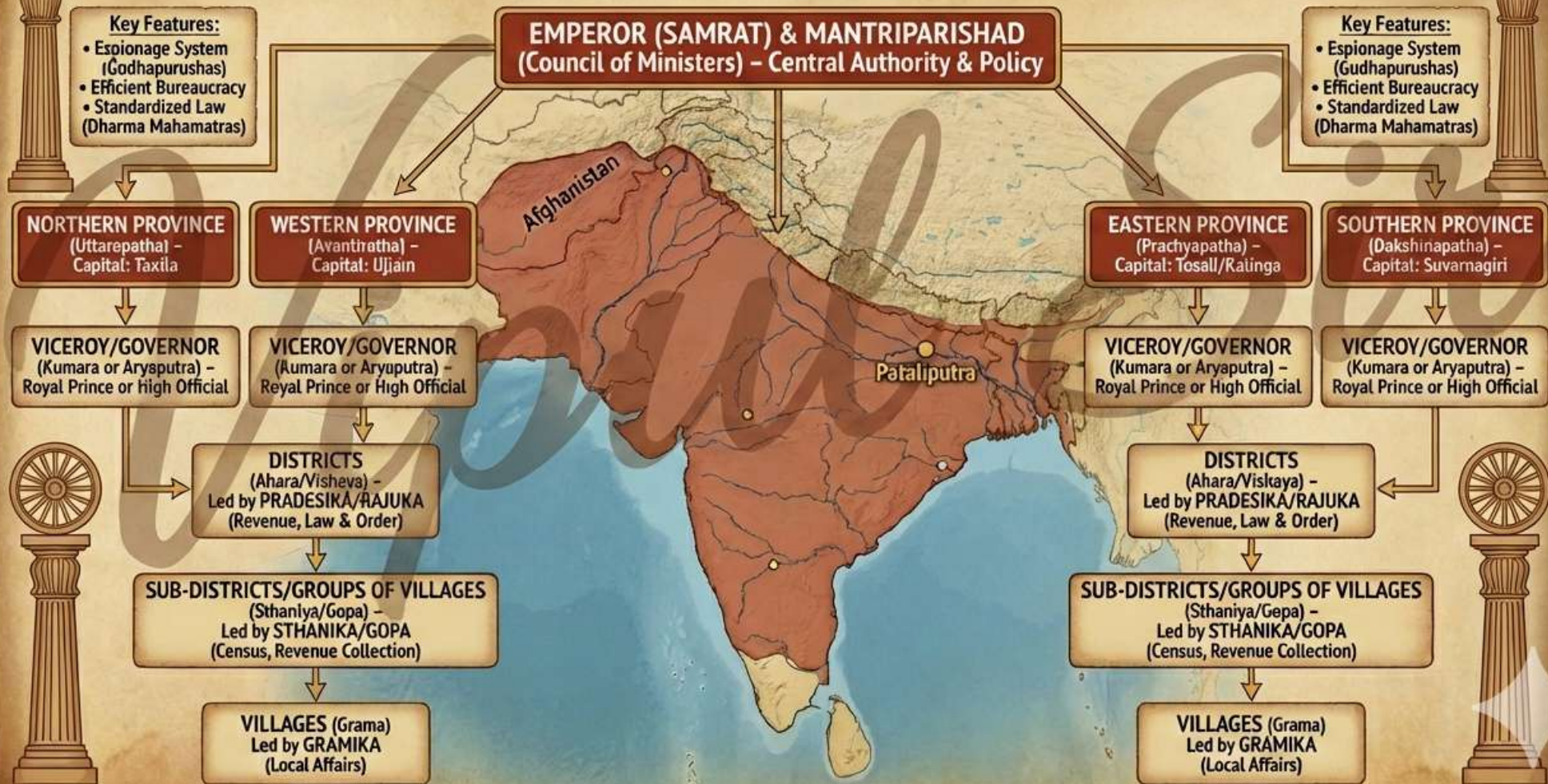
*Assassinated by: Pushyamitra Shunga (his own commander-in-chief)*

*New Dynasty: Shunga Dynasty established*





# ADMINISTRATIVE HIERARCHY OF THE MAURYAN EMPIRE (c. 322–185 BCE)









## 12. IMPORTANT FACTS - QUICK REVISION



### Numbers to Remember



| Fact                               | Number                           |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Duration of Mauryan Empire         | ~137 years                       |
| Chandragupta's reign               | 24 years                         |
| Ashoka's reign                     | 36 years                         |
| Ashokan Major Rock Edicts          | 14                               |
| Ashokan Pillar Edicts              | 7                                |
| Municipal Committees (Pataliputra) | 6 boards × 5 members = 30        |
| Military Board                     | 6 committees × 5 members = 30    |
| Army strength (Infantry)           | 600,000                          |
| War Elephants                      | 9,000                            |
| Stupas built by Ashoka             | 84,000 (traditional)             |
| Kalinga War casualties             | 100,000 killed, 150,000 deported |

### Important Personalities



| Person                 | Role/Significance                               |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Chanakya/Kautilya      | Prime Minister, author of Arthashastra          |
| Megasthenes            | Greek ambassador, wrote Indica                  |
| Deimachus              | Greek ambassador to Bindusara                   |
| Upagupta               | Buddhist teacher of Ashoka                      |
| Pushyamitra Shunga     | Assassinated last Mauryan king                  |
| Mahendra & Sanghamitra | Ashoka's children, spread Buddhism to Sri Lanka |



### Important Terms



| Term             | Meaning                                   |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Arthashastra     | Treatise on statecraft                    |
| Dhamma           | Ashoka's policy of righteousness          |
| Dhamma Mahamatra | Officers to spread Dhamma                 |
| Rajjukas         | Officers for land measurement and justice |
| Yuktas           | Subordinate officers                      |
| Pradeshikas      | District officers                         |
| Sarthavaha       | Caravan leader                            |





### 13. COMPARISON WITH OTHER ANCIENT EMPIRES

| Aspect       | Mauryan                    | Roman                      | Persian                      |
|--------------|----------------------------|----------------------------|------------------------------|
| Peak Period  | 3rd century BCE            | 1st-2nd century CE         | 5th century BCE              |
| Area         | ~5 million km <sup>2</sup> | ~5 million km <sup>2</sup> | ~5.5 million km <sup>2</sup> |
| Capital      | Pataliputra                | Rome                       | Persepolis                   |
| Famous Ruler | Ashoka                     | Augustus                   | Cyrus                        |

### 14. LEGACY OF THE MAURYAN EMPIRE

-  **Political Unity** – First pan-Indian empire
- Administrative Model** – Influenced later Indian empires
-  **Spread of Buddhism** – Became a world religion
-  **National Symbols** – Lion Capital (National Emblem), Ashoka Chakra (National Flag)
- Rock Edicts** – First written records of Indian history
-  **Diplomatic Relations** – Established ties with Greeks
- Infrastructure** – Roads, rest houses, irrigation
- Art & Architecture** – Established Indian sculptural traditions

*Thank you*

PARAMOUNT COACHING INSTITUTE DELHI

